

Pregnancy and birth services

Having a baby is an exciting time. No matter your circumstances, involving health services early and fully understanding your childbirth options will give you a great start to a rewarding birth experience. Learn about who's who during pregnancy, birth and newborn care. Understand which records and paperwork are required as well as payment options for having a baby and newborn care in Victoria.

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Options for pregnancy and birth Planning for a baby

Pregnancy and birth services -Programs and services

Pregnancy and birth services explained Rights and responsibilities

Tests, scans and appointments Unplanned pregnancy and family planning

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Complex pregnancy and birth



- **Congenital anomalies (birth defects)**

Congenital anomalies (birth defects) are structural or functional differences in a baby's body or genetics that are there before birth.

(<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/conditionsandtreatments/congenital-anomalies>)

- **Death of a baby**

Miscarriage, stillbirth or neonatal death is a shattering event for those expecting a baby. Grief and anxiety about subsequent pregnancies are common in these circumstances but counselling can help.

(<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/healthyliving/death-of-a-baby>)

- **Diabetes - gestational**

Gestational diabetes is diabetes that occurs during pregnancy and usually disappears when the pregnancy is over.

(<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/conditionsandtreatments/diabetes-gestational>)

- **Miscarriage**

A range of feelings is normal after a miscarriage, and they often linger for some time.

(<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/healthyliving/miscarriage>)

- **Premature babies**

Sometimes premature labour can be delayed to increase a baby's chance of survival.

(<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/healthyliving/premature-babies>)

Labour and birth



- **Childbirth - pain relief options**

Understanding your pain relief options can help you cope better with the pain of childbirth.

(<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/healthyliving/childbirth-pain-relief-options>)

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(<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/healthyliving/death-of-a-baby>)

- **Developing a birth plan**

A birth plan is a written summary of your preferences for when you are in labour and giving birth.

(<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/servicesandsupport/developing-a-birth-plan>)

- **Doula**

A doula, or birth attendant, is a birth companion who provides emotional, physical and non-medical support to women during pregnancy, labour, birth and postpartum.

(<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/servicesandsupport/doula>)

- **Overdue babies**

Only about 5 per cent of pregnant women actually give birth on the exact date they are due.

(<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/servicesandsupport/overdue-babies>)

- **Pregnancy - tests and scans**

A range of tests and scans are available to pregnant women to confirm pregnancy and monitor the baby's development in the womb.

(<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/servicesandsupport/pregnancy-tests-and-scans>)

- **Pregnancy and birth care options**

Pregnant women in Victoria can choose who will care for them during their pregnancy, where they would like to give birth and how they would like to deliver their baby.

(<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/servicesandsupport/pregnancy-and-birth-care-options>)

- **Who's who during pregnancy, birth and newborn care**

Depending on the model of care you chose for your antenatal and labour care, you might see a few or all of the healthcare professionals listed below who will take care of you during your pregnancy.

<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/servicesandsupport/whos-who-during-pregnancy-birth-and-newborn-care>

Newborn care and early parenting



- **Maternal and Child Health services**

Your local Maternal and Child Health (MCH) is a free service available to all Victorian families with children from birth to school age.

<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/healthyliving/maternal-and-child-health-services>

- **First days after birth**

Learn about newborn care, including skin-to-skin bonding, bathing safely, postnatal recovery and depression.

<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/servicesandsupport/first-days-after-birth>

- **First weeks after birth**

Use help and advice from family, friends and healthcare services to stay healthy, happy and well supported during the first few weeks after childbirth.

<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/servicesandsupport/first-weeks-after-birth>

- **Newborn bloodspot screening**

Every newborn baby in Australia is offered a test for the rare medical conditions of phenylketonuria, hypothyroidism, cystic fibrosis and congenital adrenal hyperplasia.

<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/conditionsandtreatments/newborn-screening>

- **Personal and relationship services**

There are personal and relationship services available to you that offer counselling and relationship advice.

<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/servicesandsupport/personal-and-relationship-services>

- **Specialised care for your baby**

If your baby is sick at birth or born premature they will be cared for in a Neonatal Intensive Care Unit (NICU) or Special Care Nursery (SCN) to support feeding, breathing and early development.

<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/servicesandsupport/specialised-care-for-your-baby>

- **Women's Sexual and Reproductive Health Hubs**

Sexual and Reproductive Health Hubs provide a range of sexual and reproductive health services for Victorian women, girls and gender diverse people.

(<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/sexual-and-reproductive-health-hubs>)

Options for pregnancy and birth



- **Doula**

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- **Homebirth**

Having a baby at home can be an option for pregnant women who are healthy, have a low-risk pregnancy and live close to a hospital in case the birth does not go to plan.

(<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/servicesandsupport/homebirth>)

- **Koori Maternity Services**

The Koori Maternity Services program offers flexible, inclusive, culturally appropriate pregnancy and postnatal care to Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander women in Victoria.

(<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/service-profiles/koori-maternity-services>)

- **Pregnancy and birth care options**

Pregnant women in Victoria can choose who will care for them during their pregnancy, where they would like to give birth and how they would like to deliver their baby.

(<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/servicesandsupport/pregnancy-and-birth-care-options>)

- **Questions to ask your obstetrician or midwife**

The cost of having a baby in Victoria can vary considerably, depending mostly on whether you use the public or private health system.

(<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/servicesandsupport/Questions-to-ask-your-obstetrician-or-midwife>)

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Planning for a baby



- **Conceiving a baby**

Most women under the age of 40 years who want to become pregnant (conceive) will achieve this within 12 months of starting to try. Here we explain how you can improve your chances of pregnancy.

(<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/healthyliving/Conceiving-a-baby>)

- **Paying for pregnancy, birth and newborn baby care**

The cost of having a baby in Victoria can vary considerably, depending mostly on whether you use the public or private health system.

(<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/servicesandsupport/paying-for-pregnancy-birth-and-newborn-care>)

- **Pregnancy - medication, drugs and alcohol**

Most women take a drug of some kind during pregnancy, sometimes without realising the potential for harm.

(<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/healthyliving/pregnancy-medication-drugs-and-alcohol>)

- **Pregnancy - week by week**

Pregnancy is divided into 3 trimesters and lasts around 40 weeks.

Includes details of what happens each week from conception to birth, embryo size, baby development and where to get help.

(<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/healthyliving/pregnancy-week-by-week>)

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(<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/servicesandsupport/pregnancy-and-birth-care-options>)

- **Pregnancy support - fathers, partners and carers**

Whether you are the baby's father, the pregnant woman's partner or are supporting a single mother-to-be, you have a crucial role in ensuring she gets the pregnancy support she needs.

(<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/servicesandsupport/pregnancy-support-fathers-partners-and-carers>)

- **Weight, fertility and pregnancy health**

Compared with women in the healthy weight range, women who are carrying extra weight are less likely to conceive.

(<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/conditionsandtreatments/weight-fertility-and-pregnancy-health>)

- **Who's who during pregnancy, birth and newborn care**

Depending on the model of care you chose for your antenatal and labour care, you might see a few or all of the healthcare professionals listed below who will take care of you during your pregnancy.

<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/servicesandsupport/whos-who-during-pregnancy-birth-and-newborn-care>

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Pregnancy and birth services -Programs and services



- **Aboriginal Women's Health Clinic**

The Aboriginal Women's Health Clinic is a free, dedicated health service for Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander women in Victoria. It provides culturally safe holistic care.

<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/services-and-support/aboriginal-womens-health-clinic>

- **Koori Maternity Services**

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- **Mobile Women's Health Clinic**

The Mobile Women's Health Clinic services rural and regional Victoria. It has services for women's health, sexual and reproductive health, and health education and support.

<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/services-and-support/mobile-womens-health-clinic>

- **Nurse-on-Call - 1300 60 60 24**

Nurse-on-Call is a free, confidential telephone helpline that provides immediate, expert health advice from a registered nurse, 24 hours a day, 7 days a week.

<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/serviceprofiles/nurse-on-call-service>

- **Virtual Women's Health Clinic**

The Virtual Women's Health Clinic offers free, confidential telehealth support for women's health issues. Women, girls, and gender diverse people can access free appointments without referrals.

<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/services-and-support/virtual-womens-health-clinic>

- **Women's Health Clinics**

Women's Health Clinics are for all women, girls and gender diverse people aged 16 years and over, living in Victoria. Referrals will be required for most services.

(<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/services-and-support/womens-health-clinics>)

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Pregnancy and birth services explained



- **Doula**

A doula, or birth attendant, is a birth companion who provides emotional, physical and non-medical support to women during pregnancy, labour, birth and postpartum.

(<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/servicesandsupport/doula>)

- **Maternal and Child Health services**

Your local Maternal and Child Health (MCH) is a free service available to all Victorian families with children from birth to school age.

(<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/healthyliving/maternal-and-child-health-services>)

- **Medical terms and definitions during pregnancy and birth**

Like all areas of medicine, pregnancy and childbirth has a number of specialised terms, many of which you will hear during your own pregnancy and labour, and the birth of your baby.

(<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/servicesandsupport/medical-terms-and-definitions-during-pregnancy-and-birth>)

- **Paying for pregnancy, birth and newborn baby care**

The cost of having a baby in Victoria can vary considerably, depending mostly on whether you use the public or private health system.

(<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/servicesandsupport/paying-for-pregnancy-birth-and-newborn-care>)

- **Pregnancy and birth care options**

Pregnant women in Victoria can choose who will care for them during their pregnancy, where they would like to give birth and how they would like to deliver their baby.

(<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/servicesandsupport/pregnancy-and-birth-care-options>)

- **Pregnancy and birthing services for different language or cultural needs**

If you are pregnant and have specific cultural or language needs, the first step is to notify your local maternity hospital about your requirements.

<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/servicesandsupport/pregnancy-and-birthing-services-for-different-language-or-cultural-needs>

- **Records and paperwork for maternal health care and babies**

When you are having a baby in Victoria, there are various records and other documents that need to be accessed, created or completed.

<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/servicesandsupport/records-and-paperwork-for-maternal-health-care-and-babies>

- **Who's who during pregnancy, birth and newborn care**

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Rights and responsibilities



- **Confidentiality and privacy in healthcare**

There are laws that set out how healthcare professionals can collect and store your health information and when they are allowed to share it.

<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/servicesandsupport/confidentiality-and-privacy-in-healthcare>

- **Patient and carer rights in hospital**

You and your carers should expect clear communication about medical issues and treatment options and costs in hospital in a way that you can understand.

<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/servicesandsupport/patient-and-carer-rights-in-hospital>

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Tests, scans and appointments



- **Maternal and Child Health services**

Your local Maternal and Child Health (MCH) is a free service available to all Victorian families with children from birth to school age.

(<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/healthyliving/maternal-and-child-health-services>)

- **Pregnancy - antenatal checks of your baby**

A midwife or doctor will use abdominal palpation during an antenatal visit to examine a baby's position and development.

(<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/servicesandsupport/pregnancy-antenatal-checks-of-your-baby>)

- **Pregnancy - tests and scans**

A range of tests and scans are available to pregnant women to confirm pregnancy and monitor the baby's development in the womb.

(<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/servicesandsupport/pregnancy-tests-and-scans>)

- **Pregnancy and birth care options**

Pregnant women in Victoria can choose who will care for them during their pregnancy, where they would like to give birth and how they would like to deliver their baby.

(<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/servicesandsupport/pregnancy-and-birth-care-options>)

- **Pregnancy tests - maternal serum screening**

Maternal serum screening can indicate increased risk of abnormalities in the unborn child, but is not a diagnosis.

(<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/conditionsandtreatments/pregnancy-tests-maternal-serum-screening>)

- **Pregnancy tests - ultrasound**

Ultrasound is used during pregnancy to check the baby's development and to help pick up any abnormalities.

(<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/healthyliving/pregnancy-tests-ultrasound>)

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(<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/sexual-and-reproductive-health-hubs>)

Unplanned pregnancy and family planning



- **Abortion in Victoria**

Abortion is a safe and legal medical procedure in Victoria. Find out more about abortion services and where to get help.

(<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/healthyliving/abortion-in-victoria>)

- **Abortion information translated into community languages**

In Victoria, you can have two types of abortion: surgical and medication. Both types are safe and reliable. You can have a medication abortion up to nine weeks of pregnancy. You can have a surgical abortion from around six weeks of pregnancy onwards.

(<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/healthyliving/abortion-translated>)

- **Abortion procedures - medication**

Information about medical abortion (or the 'abortion pill') - includes how medication works, appointments, what to expect, side effects, possible risks, self-care.

(<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/healthyliving/abortion-procedures-medication>)

- **Abortion procedures - surgical**

Abortion is one of the most common and safest types of surgery in Australia.

(<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/healthyliving/abortion-procedures-surgical>)

- **Contraception - choices**

Different methods of contraception available in Australia - includes LARC implants and IUDs, injections, contraceptive pills, condoms, diaphragm, vaginal ring, sterilisation, natural and withdrawal.

(<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/healthyliving/contraception-choices>)

- **Contraception information translated into community languages**

This page shows you where to find translated information about the different methods of contraception (how to prevent getting pregnant) available in Australia

(<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/healthyliving/contraception-translated>)

- **Pregnancy options**

If you are pregnant and do not want to be, you have choice. Find information about pregnancy options (such as medical and surgical abortion, and adoption), pregnancy counselling and where to get help.

(<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/servicesandsupport/pregnancy-options>)

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A-Z of Services and support →

(<http://www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/a-zservicesandsupport>)

Reviewed on: 10-03-2023



The Victorian Government acknowledges Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander people as the Traditional Custodians of the land and acknowledges and pays respect to their Elders, past and present.

The Department of Health celebrates, values and includes people of all backgrounds, genders, sexualities, cultures, bodies and abilities.

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